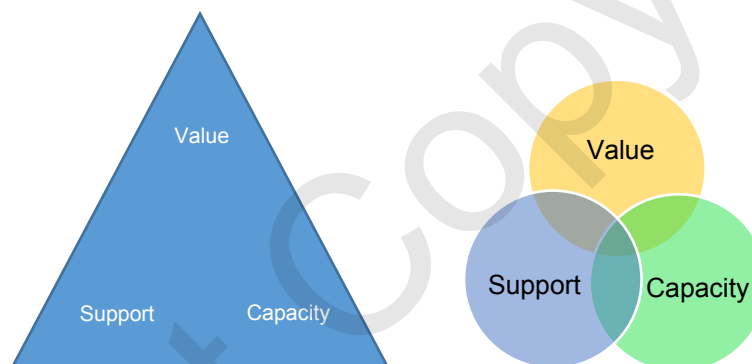


Strategic Alignment for Policy Analysis and Design

A successful policy has three characteristics. It promises to produce net public value. It is operationally feasible—that is, the resources (financial, legal, technical, personnel, managerial) necessary to bring it about are available or realistically obtainable. And it is politically feasible, which means that the stakeholders whose support is required endorse its purposes and believe in its operational feasibility.

This property of “strategic alignment” is the focus of a simple conceptual framework that has long been used and taught at the Harvard Kennedy School. While the strategic alignment orientation has roots in the classic corporate-strategy literature it has been extensively adapted for public and non-profit settings, especially by HKS professor Mark H. Moore.¹

Graphic aids can reinforce the notion of aligning value, support, and operational feasibility. Common visuals include an equilateral triangle or three partly-overlapping circles. These graphics (unlike decisions trees or logic maps, for example) are not really analytical tools *per se*, and their detailed configurations are seldom important. They are essentially mnemonics, meant to anchor attention to the challenge of forging and maintaining alignment.



Achieving strategic alignment typically requires a broad portfolio of analytical tools and concepts. Economics, philosophy, statistics and other disciplines including sociology and psychology may be brought to bear to calibrate the value of policy goals. Organizational analysis, management theory, and operations analysis can help determine operational feasibility. Political science, public-opinion research, and negotiation analysis (among other tools) can be used to predict political feasibility. Decision theory, simulations, cognitive science, modeling, and scenario analysis can illuminate multiple aspects of the puzzle.

¹ Moore develops the theme most fully in *Creating Public Value* (Harvard University Press, 1995). Many other scholars, notably including Herman B. Leonard, have also contributed to the strategic-alignment framework.

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Some examples

Examples of successful strategic alignment for public purposes—from the banal to the historic—are legion.

Policy Example	Value	Operational Feasibility	Political Feasibility
Removing snow from city streets and sidewalks	Promptly and reliably clearing snow promotes citizens' convenience and safety.	Money plus basic managerial capacity enables plowing by either contractors or city workers.	Citizens and their representatives generally support—indeed, demand—snow removal and are relatively tolerant of the associated taxes.
Combatting malaria in poor areas	Lower rates of malaria infection produce large health, fiscal, and economic benefits, which can serve to reduce chronic poverty and inequality.	A range of simple and low-cost interventions, notably including bed nets, are effective against malaria. In many countries there are multiple public and NGO channels for implementing these interventions.	Host-country governments usually favor and virtually never oppose anti-malaria campaigns. These campaigns attract financial support from governments, non-governmental organizations, and even individuals.
Winning the Second World War	By most moral standards the Axis agenda was deplorable, and defeating it militarily—despite the large losses entailed—was on balance a great good.	The Allies—led by the Soviet Union and the United States—were able to assemble the personnel, materiel, and strategic capability to prevail.	Allied populations were—eventually and on balance—supportive of the war effort and accepting of the financial and other sacrifices required to win it.

The reader can no doubt summon many more examples from her studies or experience.

Three caveats

First, it is rare that any aspect of an ostensibly aligned policy is beyond dispute. There were Americans and Britons in the 1940s—not just Germans, Japanese, or Italians—who sincerely believed that greater virtue lay with the Axis than the Allied powers. Someone can agree with the value to be pursued but vigorously contest the causal logic of a policy—for example, proposing a crash campaign to develop drugs conferring resistance instead of endless efforts to block human contact with infected mosquitos. Similarly, one can challenge the workability of the means proposed to implement a policy, or insist that a particular policy goal *would* be worthy of support if it were efficiently pursued but is not in the wasteful status quo. Or, very commonly, an individual might believe that some policy goal is indeed valuable—but in a setting of constrained resources, not as valuable as the cause closest to his heart. So a realistic ambition is usually “good enough” rather than perfect alignment.

Second, alignment is usually *constructed* through cognition and action rather than discovered. The American system of electoral democracy has worked tolerably well for nearly 230 years, and may seem like a self-evidently sensible way to run a complex and diverse polity. But virtually every feature was hard-won, first in the intellectual work of design and then in the political work of enactment.

Third, alignment is characteristically *unstable*. Affinities among purpose, operational capacity, and support are prone to break down. In most settings one or more elements of the triangle will be in flux, undermining the stability of the whole. Any particular policy configuration may stay in alignment for years—or may break, perhaps repeatedly, over the course of a year or even a day. The prudent policy analyst will assume that alignment is quite fragile, and remain poised for repair. In this spirit of continuous iteration the alignment orientation resonates with “agile design,” as well as with the “Problem Driven Iterative Adaptation” framework that has also been developed by Harvard Kennedy School faculty.²

Misalignment

Failure to achieve alignment, or to maintain it once achieved, is lamentably prevalent. There are three basic types of misalignment.

Valuable and supported but not operationally feasible. In our imperfect world there are many, many goals that would be highly valuable and enthusiastically supported but simply cannot be achieved. A once-and-for-all cancer cure meets this description. So does ensuring that every child succeeds at school. So do reversing climate change, eliminating ethnic tensions, and achieving peace on earth. We can make progress toward each, but we just don’t have what it takes to fully get it done.

Operational capacity is elastic, and things that are not possible today can become possible tomorrow. This is how our species progresses. President Kennedy’s vision of a manned lunar landing was not feasible when he issued the challenge. But it was achieved within a few years as the martyred president’s memory inspired Herculean efforts. This was an exceptional occurrence, however. Almost any goal can be rendered feasible if all else can be subordinated to its pursuit. But in a diverse society with multiple priorities such concentrated effort is very rare.

Valuable and achievable but not politically feasible. Sometimes the capacity exists to accomplish some arguably valuable goal. But the goal is not met because those whose support is essential decline to provide it. Recall one canonical example of successful alignment, the Allied victory in World War II. This was (we’ll simply stipulate) a good thing. And the combined population and industrial resources of the USSR, the Commonwealth, and the United States made victory at least latently feasible from the start. But the American citizenry—and thus Congress—opposed US entry into the war for many years, withholding a crucial ingredient of actual feasibility.

Such situations summon a standard lament: “We just need political will!” But the reasons political will is absent seldom melt before this incantation. People can disagree about the outcome that should be willed into feasibility. Some Americans would say that a deficit of political will prevents an end to abortion; others that it blocks full reproductive rights. Even when there is consensus that some goal is valuable, people may have other

² Matt Andrews, et al., “Escaping Capability Traps Through PDIA,” Center for International Development Working Paper 240, 2012.

goals (as noted earlier) that they are unwilling to set aside in its service. (Many Americans who loathed and feared fascism in 1940 still cared more about the lives of their husbands and sons.) Political feasibility, like operational feasibility, can be expanded. But seldom easily.

Achievable and politically supported, but not valuable. To stalwart democrats this whole category may ring false. If the public supports a policy is it not by definition valuable? But there are multiple reasons why an operationally and politically feasible policy may nonetheless be a bad one. Some societies—including the world's largest country—simply reject popular support as the metric of a policy's worth. Even countries that revere majority rule for most purposes hold that some things (such as basic rights) are valuable even when a majority disagrees. The political-support test may also be a flawed guide to value for policies that are good for those with political resources but bad for those who lack them—including future generations. It is wise to tread extremely carefully when claiming that political support does not reflect a policy's "true" worth. But this surely happens. Human slavery was politically and operationally feasible in the United States until 1865.

Impediments to disciplined thinking about alignment

Misalignment chronically plagues policy proposals and even long-standing public and non-profit operations. This is in part because strategic alignment is hard to forge and quick to fail. But it is also because misalignment can be difficult to diagnose. And because policy designers and analysts—and those for and with whom they work—often have both the motive and the means to persuade themselves that alignment exists when it does not.

Stakeholders of well-established policies are prone to self-deception about value. If you work within an undertaking that is operationally feasible and politically supported you might resist subtle clues—or even vivid signals—that its outcomes are not very valuable. The "DARE" program (Drug Abuse Resistance Education) brings local police to public schools to warn children against the perils of drugs. Study after study has found the program ineffective, without notably affecting its popularity among law-enforcement or education personnel. Further examples abound. Analytic discipline to identify low-value activities is especially desirable in the public and non-profit worlds where market tests are generally absent. But desirability does not make it common.

Advocates for new policy ideas generally have less incentive than stakeholders invested in established policies to misperceive value (though they do have some). Rather, their characteristic form of indiscipline tends to be ill-founded confidence about operational feasibility or political feasibility or both. It is natural for proponents to assume that others will share their enthusiasm, and to neglect uncomfortable questions about whether funders, legislators, taxpayers, and other stakeholders have competing priorities or even divergent values. Likewise, advocates often delude themselves that adequate operational capacity already exists, or that the inevitable outpouring of support will let it be built in short order. Cultivating a habit of skeptical, systematic thinking about alignment can reduce the risk of falling into these errors.

A final observation

Remember that the alignment framework isn't a stand-alone tool. It is not a substitute for the many ways—ranging from formal analytic methods to well-tempered intuition—we ask and answer questions relevant to policy design. It is a cue to use them.